Before the Bharat Jodo Yatra kicked off on 7 September 2023, few inside or outside the party could have predicted the outcome of what was regarded as a significant political gamble—one that was taking up an appreciable portion of the party's time and resources.

The Yatra turned out to be a jolt of pure adrenaline that ran through the Congress's system. Sometimes the act of doing is a precursor to believing. Pulling off such a huge exercise had a direct positive impact on both the leadership and the cadre.

In Kerala and Tamil Nadu we saw the infectious, organic energy of the crowds and a rock-solid party cadre that was an inspiration to the rest of the country. The Karnataka Congress took the occasion to flex its organizational muscle and prepare for the upcoming state election. States such as Maharashtra were remarkable for their large organic crowds and the participation of civil society. Professionals, intellectuals, farmers, small businessmen, women, children and senior citizens—the Yatra gave the Congress the opportunity to engage with all of them at the grassroots level on a scale and at a tempo rarely seen outside of electoral politics.

We witnessed, perhaps after a significant period of time, the coming together of a wide range of intellectual and activist points of view on a common national platform of opposition to the BJP–RSS combine. This happened not only because the Yatra's core ideology of unity, diversity and tolerance had gained traction in an environment of communal and social divisiveness, but also because during the Yatra the Congress actively engaged diverse individuals, from professors and writers to labour union leaders, actors, journalists, doctors and jurists.

The Yatra was irrefutable proof, as much to outsiders as within the party itself, that the Congress was alive and kicking.

But it's not what happens in the limelight that defines us. It's the men and women who joined the Yatra with complete disregard for self-publicity. The Pandeys from Madhya Pradesh—a husband and wife team—who, unbidden, walked with us since Kanyakumari; Mohit from Haryana who slept overnight in fields, seeking shelter in villages; Congressman P. Ganesh from Tamil Nadu, who passed away after being hit by a speeding